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7-Night Western Caribbean — Hosted Solo Group

*MSC World America · 7 Nights from PortMiami
April 24 – May 1, 2027 · Hosted by Denise Sheets Ferguson*



MSC World America at sea — MSC Cruises' second World-class
ship, delivered March 2025

A Voyage Pack from **In the Wake**

Hosted by **Denise Sheets Ferguson** · Booked through **Maulsby Travel Co.**

Welcome

This pack exists to make one specific cruise easier: **MSC World America**, sailing 7 nights from PortMiami, **April 24 – May 1, 2027**, calling at **Roatán (Honduras), Costa Maya (Mexico), Cozumel (Mexico), and Ocean Cay (Bahamas)**. It's a **hosted solo cruisers group cruise** organized by **Denise Sheets Ferguson**, with the booking handled by **Tina Maulsby** at **Maulsby Travel Co.**

Two people, two roles. Denise is your on-ship host — she's the one organizing the group dinners, the meet-and-greets, the daily where-are-we-gathering rhythm. Tina is the travel agent who booked the group rate; she's the source of truth for what's included in your fare (drinks packages, Wi-Fi, gratuities) and the right person to call if anything goes sideways pre-cruise. Use the right contact for the right question.

It is calm by design. There is no urgency, no upsell, no countdown timer. The site that produced this pack is independent — no cruise-line affiliations, no shore-excursion commissions, no display ads.

Includes an offline-capable Emergency Contacts section — a fillable family handoff card, cruise-line and consulate numbers tailored to this itinerary, available offline after first load via **In the Wake's** PWA. Designed to share with one trusted person ashore before sailing.

If you're sailing solo for the first time, you are not the only one in this group doing so. **Tina's solo cruising stories** are worth reading whether before, during, or after this trip. And if this is your first MSC sailing — even if you've cruised before — the line feels different from Royal Caribbean, Carnival, NCL, and Princess. We cover the differences in **Section 1** below.

At a Glance

Ship	MSC World America (sister: MSC World Europa , 2022)
Cruise line	MSC Cruises
Class	World Class — MSC's largest, LNG-powered
Specifications	216,638 GT · 1,093 ft / 333 m · 22 decks (16 guest-accessible) · 2,614 cabins · 5,079 double / 6,762 max guests · ~2,138 crew
Year built	2025 (Chantiers de l'Atlantique, Saint-Nazaire, France); Maltese registry
Maiden voyage	April 12, 2025 — PortMiami round-trip Caribbean
Godmother	Drew Barrymore (christened April 9, 2025 at PortMiami, with a Gloria Estefan concert)
Departure port	MSC Miami Cruise Terminal, PortMiami , Florida — the new MSC-built terminal that opened April 2025
Itinerary	7 nights / 8 days · Western Caribbean round-trip
Audience	Solo travelers (hosted group)
Group host	Denise Sheets Ferguson — on-ship host; reach her via Facebook for group communications
Booking agent	Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co. — tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077
Group rhythm	Denise sets the daily gathering plan; verify with her Facebook page or onboard once boarded. See Section 9 .

Group rates	Solo Studio \$1,068 · Ocean View \$1,358 · Interior \$1,623 · Balcony \$2,225 (per the group flyer; verify current with Tina)
Currency aboard	US Dollar

Ports of call

The verified day-by-day for the April 24 – May 1, 2027 sailing:

1. **PortMiami, Florida** — embark Sat Apr 24, ship sails late afternoon · see </ports/miami.html>
2. **Cruising at sea** — Sun Apr 25
3. **Roatán, Honduras** — Mon Apr 26
4. **Costa Maya, Mexico** — Tue Apr 27
5. **Cozumel, Mexico** — Wed Apr 28
6. **Cruising at sea** — Thu Apr 29
7. **Ocean Cay MSC Marine Reserve, Bahamas** — Fri Apr 30 (MSC's private island)
8. **PortMiami, Florida** — disembark Sat May 1

All five ports have full standalone port pages on this site. **Verify your specific arrival/departure times in the MSC for Me app** — they shift slightly between sailings.

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Section 1 — Your Ship: MSC World America

A class-defining ship in her second year of service

MSC World America was delivered March 27, 2025 by Chantiers de l'Atlantique at Saint-Nazaire, France — the second ship of MSC's **World Class** and the first dedicated to the US market. Her maiden voyage left PortMiami on April 12, 2025. By your April 2027 sailing she's two years into service: past any new-ship teething, with the operating crew well-trained and the Caribbean rotation in steady rhythm. For broader context on MSC's positioning in the Caribbean alongside Royal, NCL, and Virgin, **Caribbean Cruise Trends 2026** covers the deployment shifts.

She was christened by actress **Drew Barrymore** at PortMiami on April 9, 2025, with Orlando Bloom on hand and Gloria Estefan performing a concert from the deck. At **216,638 GT and 1,093 feet long**, she's MSC's largest ship and one of the largest cruise ships in the world. Her direct sister is **MSC World Europa** (2022), homeported in the Mediterranean. For a side-by-side comparison against other Caribbean megaships you may have sailed (Symphony of the Seas, Norwegian Aqua, Carnival Mardi Gras, etc.), the **Ship Size Atlas** shows the actual relative scale on a single chart.

What's distinctive about World America

A few features set her apart from anything else sailing in 2027:

- **The Y-shaped aft.** Most ships have a flat stern. World America's stern is a wedge — a Y-shape with three floor-to-ceiling glass walls that frame the wake. The **World Promenade** (Deck 8) is the seven-deck outdoor walkway that wraps the aft Y, with bars and seating at the rail. The Panorama Lounge above it puts the same view behind a glass wall for cooler evenings.
- **The World Galleria** — a three-deck central atrium with an LED ceiling that changes scenes throughout the day. The architectural centerpiece of the ship.
- **The Venom Drop @ The Spiral** — an 11-deck dry slide, the longest at sea. Not a waterslide — a dry, friction-controlled enclosed drop. Free.
- **Eataly at sea.** World America carries the first floating Eataly — the Italian gourmet brand's fresh-pasta, wood-fired-pizza, and gelato concept. Specialty dining (extra charge). On Deck 8.
- **Decks named after Americas port cities** — Cozumel, Nassau, Santos, Miami, Seattle, Halifax, Los Angeles, Buenos Aires, New York, Ocean Cay, San Juan, Ocho Rios. Wayfinding gets easier once you've learned the geography metaphor.
- **LNG-powered.** Dual-fuel engines plus Bloom Energy solid-oxide fuel cells. She burns natural gas, not heavy fuel oil — significantly lower particulate emissions. Practically: less engine vibration in lower-deck cabins; the working ports below the buffet are quieter.

What's NOT on World America

Things you might expect from her size that she doesn't have:

- **No Cirque du Soleil.** MSC's longstanding Cirque partnership ended before her delivery; she launched without it. The replacement is in-house production shows at the **World Theatre** and a new comedy/karaoke lounge called **The Loft**.

- **No waterpark.** There's an Aqua Park (water-play features for kids and an outdoor pool deck) but nothing on the scale of Royal's Perfect Day at CocoCay or Carnival's Excel-class waterworks. The big aft attraction is the Venom Drop dry slide, not waterslides.
- **No traditional formal nights.** MSC has a "Gala Evening" once or twice per sailing (suit/cocktail-dress encouraged) but it's softer than the legacy "formal night" of Holland America or Cunard. Most guests dress smart-casual all week and put on something nicer on Gala Evening.

Cabin categories — the solo calculus

Before you commit, run the stateroom sanity check — a four-question filter that catches the bookings most likely to leave a cruiser unhappy. The cabin-organization article (**cruise-cabin-organization**) covers the small-space pragmatics once you've chosen.

The group flyer shows four price points: **Solo Studio \$1,068, Ocean View \$1,358, Interior \$1,623, Balcony \$2,225**. How the four price points compare:

- **Solo Studio at \$1,068** is the price-leader and the obvious choice if budget matters more than space. MSC's solo-traveler offering on World America is functionally a small interior cabin priced without a single supplement. You're trading square footage and a window for the lowest possible solo price on a brand-new ship. If you're a confident solo traveler who'll be in the cabin to sleep, shower, and change, this is the rate to take.
- **Interior at \$1,623** is *more expensive* than the Ocean View — verify with Tina that this isn't a typo on the flyer. Standard MSC pricing has Ocean View above Interior, not the other way around. The flyer is the flyer; if the numbers are correct as posted, the Ocean View is the better value of the two.
- **Ocean View at \$1,358** is a real upgrade over Solo Studio: a window cabin, daylight in the morning, the world feeling different. For a \$290 upcharge on a solo week, this is the value pick for most solo cruisers who'd appreciate a window.

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- **Balcony at \$2,225** is the bigger jump. A private outdoor space matters more on a Caribbean cruise than on Alaska — sea-day sunrises, port-day return-from-shore decompression, evenings on the balcony with a book. If the differential is workable, the balcony changes the texture of the week.

MSC Yacht Club is not on the flyer at these rates. Yacht Club is MSC's ship-within-a-ship suite product — 159 suites on World America, private restaurant, private pool deck, private bar, butler service, full embarkation lounge at the terminal. If you want to inquire about Yacht Club for this sailing, contact Tina; pricing is significantly higher than the published group rates, and inventory at booking time will determine availability.

Before you commit to a specific cabin number, walk through the deck plan with accessibility, motion, noise, and view considerations against your category. The **cabin organization article** covers the cross-line basics; MSC's own deck plan (linked from World America's page) is the source of truth for layouts.

Dining

World America has **20+ dining venues**. The dining map:

Included with your fare (no extra charge):

- **Four main dining rooms** on Decks 5 and 6: La Foglia, Esagono, Hexagon, Bubbles. Different room atmospheres, the same menu. MSC's MDRs run a slightly more formal European dining rhythm than the American lines — longer dinners, multiple courses, table service expected.
- **Il Mercato** (Deck 18) — the main buffet. Long hours; the upper-deck windows look down on the pool deck.
- **La Brasserie** (Deck 19) — 24/7 French-style casual. Crepes, fresh-baked bread, lighter food. This is where you go at 2 AM, and where the breakfast buffet is least crowded.
- **Luna Park Pizza & Burger** (Deck 6) — quick casual, included.
- **La Boca Grill** (Deck 18) — Argentinian/Latin American, included with fare.
- **Promenade Bites** (Deck 8) on the World Promenade — small plates and tapas, included.

Specialty dining (extra charge or part of a Specialty Dining Package):

- **Eataly** (Deck 8) — fresh pasta, wood-fired pizza, gelato. The first Eataly at sea. The reservation worth pre-booking on Day 1 if you only do one specialty meal.
- **Paxos** (Deck 8) — Greek seafood, open-air seating on the Promenade.
- **Butcher's Cut** — steakhouse.
- **Kaito Teppanyaki** and **Kaito Sushi Bar** — Japanese.
- **HOLA! Tacos & Cantina** — modern Mexican.
- **Jean-Philippe Chocolat & Café** — pastries and chocolate; partially included for some fare types, à la carte for others.
- **Masters of the Sea Pub** (Deck 7) — onboard microbrewery + pub food.

Drinks. MSC's drink package tiers (Easy / Easy+ / Premium Plus / Premium Extra) are different from NCL's or Royal's tiering. Most group sailings include a baseline Easy or Easy+ as part of "MSC Free" booking promotions; verify with Tina what's bundled in your specific group rate. **Whether you need to upgrade depends on what you actually drink** — the **drink-calculator** lets you put in your real consumption pattern. The companion article **Is the drink package worth it?** walks through the breakeven math with worked examples.

Connectivity

MSC's Wi-Fi packages are tier-based (Browse / Browse & Stream / Browse, Stream & Calls) and run separately from the drink-package promotions. Pricing is significantly cheaper if you buy a package pre-cruise versus onboard. The **internet at sea guide** covers the cross-line baseline including how to avoid cellular roaming charges in port.

For most solo cruisers in the group, the right approach is:

- Use included basic Wi-Fi if your fare includes any
- Don't try to stream video at sea

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- Use port-day cellular when possible (turn airplane mode off only at confirmed ports — Roatán uses Honduras carriers, Mexican ports use Telcel/AT&T-Mexico, Ocean Cay uses no terrestrial carriers at all)
 - Keep one trusted person ashore informed via a daily one-line message; see **Section 6 — Emergency Contacts**
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Section 2 — Day by Day

The day-by-day below uses the typical MSC World America Western Caribbean rhythm. **Verify your specific times in the MSC for Me app** — the published sequence sometimes shifts between sailings, especially around weather.

This is not your plan. What follows is one possible shape of the week, not a schedule to keep. Only a few things on it are actually fixed: the muster drill, sailaway, the ship's arrival and all-aboard times in each port, and anything you have already booked. Everything else is a suggestion you are free to ignore, reorder, or sleep through. A day spent entirely on your balcony is not a day wasted, and nothing here is a commitment you have made to anyone.

Day 1 — Saturday, April 24 — PortMiami (embarkation)

Terminal: MSC Miami Cruise Terminal at PortMiami — the new MSC-built terminal that opened in April 2025. ~492,678 square feet; MSC has marketed it as the world's largest cruise terminal. Different terminal from where Royal Caribbean and Carnival board at PortMiami; verify the MSC terminal address with Tina or the MSC for Me app before your taxi/Uber pickup.

Embark window: Typically 11:30 AM – 3:30 PM. Ship departs ~5:00 PM. All-aboard 4:00 PM. **Be at the terminal by 2:00 PM** to clear security and embarkation with margin.

Getting to PortMiami:

- **Miami International (MIA) → PortMiami:** Uber/Lyft \$30–45, 20–30 min. Taxi \$32 flat-rate.
- **Fort Lauderdale (FLL) → PortMiami:** Uber/Lyft \$60–90, 45–60 min. Cheaper if you can split with another group member.
- **If you're driving:** PortMiami parking at the **Terminal AA garage runs \$35/day** (firsthand May 2026 — verify at booking). Other terminals are in a similar range. Secure but not cheap for a week (~\$245). Offsite Miami long-term lots run \$7–14/day with shuttle service; the math favors offsite if you don't mind a 15-minute Uber to the terminal Saturday morning.

Pre-cruise hotel — strongly recommended. Same-day flights to a 3:30 PM all-aboard are risky; afternoon thunderstorms during MIA arrival windows are common. A Friday-night stay in Miami Beach, Brickell, or Downtown gives you margin and lets you use Friday afternoon for South Beach, Wynwood, Little Havana, or just sleeping off the travel.

Saturday morning before boarding. If you arrived Friday and have Saturday morning to kill: PortMiami opens for terminal arrivals around 10:30 AM, but bag drop-off via the curbside porters runs from 10:00 AM. Drop your bags, then walk Bayfront Park or the InterContinental waterfront before checking in.

The realistic Day 1 timeline:

- **10:30 AM – 12:00 PM:** Arrive terminal, security, check-in. MSC's check-in is online via the MSC for Me app — complete it before you arrive to skip a 20-minute queue.
- **12:30 PM:** Aboard. Cabins typically open by 1:30 PM; until then, lunch at the buffet (Il Mercato, Deck 18) or La Brasserie (Deck 19, calmer).
- **2:30 PM:** Cabin open. Meet your stateroom steward; drop carry-ons.

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- **3:30 PM:** Mandatory muster drill — MSC's drill is partly app-based (watch the safety video in MSC for Me) plus an in-person check-in at your assigned station. **You must complete both before sailing.**
 - **5:00 PM: Sailaway.** The World Promenade (Deck 8 aft, the seven-deck outdoor walkway around the Y-shaped stern) is the signature viewing location. Less crowded than the main pool deck; the wake unfolds directly below the rail.
 - **6:00 – 8:00 PM:** Dinner. Group dinner location and time will be set by Denise — check her Facebook page or your group communications.

What to pack in your carry-on for Day 1: swimsuit (pools open before checked bags arrive), light layer (PortMiami afternoons can hit a humid 85°F but ship interior runs ~72°F), all medications, change of clothes, passport (preferred for Caribbean itineraries — Roatán and Mexico are foreign ports), phone charger, refillable water bottle, embarkation paperwork (printed boarding pass or pulled up in MSC for Me). Your checked bags may not arrive until 7–9 PM.

Money/card: Your MSC cruise card is your room key, ID, and onboard charge account. You'll receive it at check-in or in your cabin. **Currency aboard: US Dollar.**

Day 2 — Sunday, April 25 — Cruising at sea

The settling-in day. The ship is heading southwest across the Gulf Stream and Yucatán Channel toward Roatán.

Morning: - **The World Promenade** (Deck 8 aft) for sunrise coffee. The wake view from the seven-deck Y-shaped aft is one of the ship's signature experiences. - **Breakfast at La Brasserie** (Deck 19) — calmer than Il Mercato, French-style with fresh pastries and crepes. - **Solo-cruiser social space** — MSC's solo program is newer than NCL's; whether World America runs a dedicated solo-cabin lounge with hosted hours varies. Verify with Denise or at Guest Services on Day 1. MSC Yacht Club (a separate suite-class enclave) does have its own lounge.

Mid-morning to lunch — pick ONE:

- **Climb the Venom Drop @ The Spiral.** The 11-deck dry slide is busiest mid-afternoon. The first hour after it opens (typically 10 AM) is the shortest line.
- **MSC Aurea Spa thermal-suite day pass** — sea-day mornings are when introductory rates appear. Steam rooms, sauna, heated loungers; about 90 minutes is the right dose.
- **Eataly cooking demo** if scheduled — World America runs a pasta-making class on some sea days. Check the daily program (delivered to your cabin nightly or in MSC for Me).
- **The Galleria atrium** — three decks of LED ceiling, the day's best photo if you've never seen it. Skip the rope line and just wander.

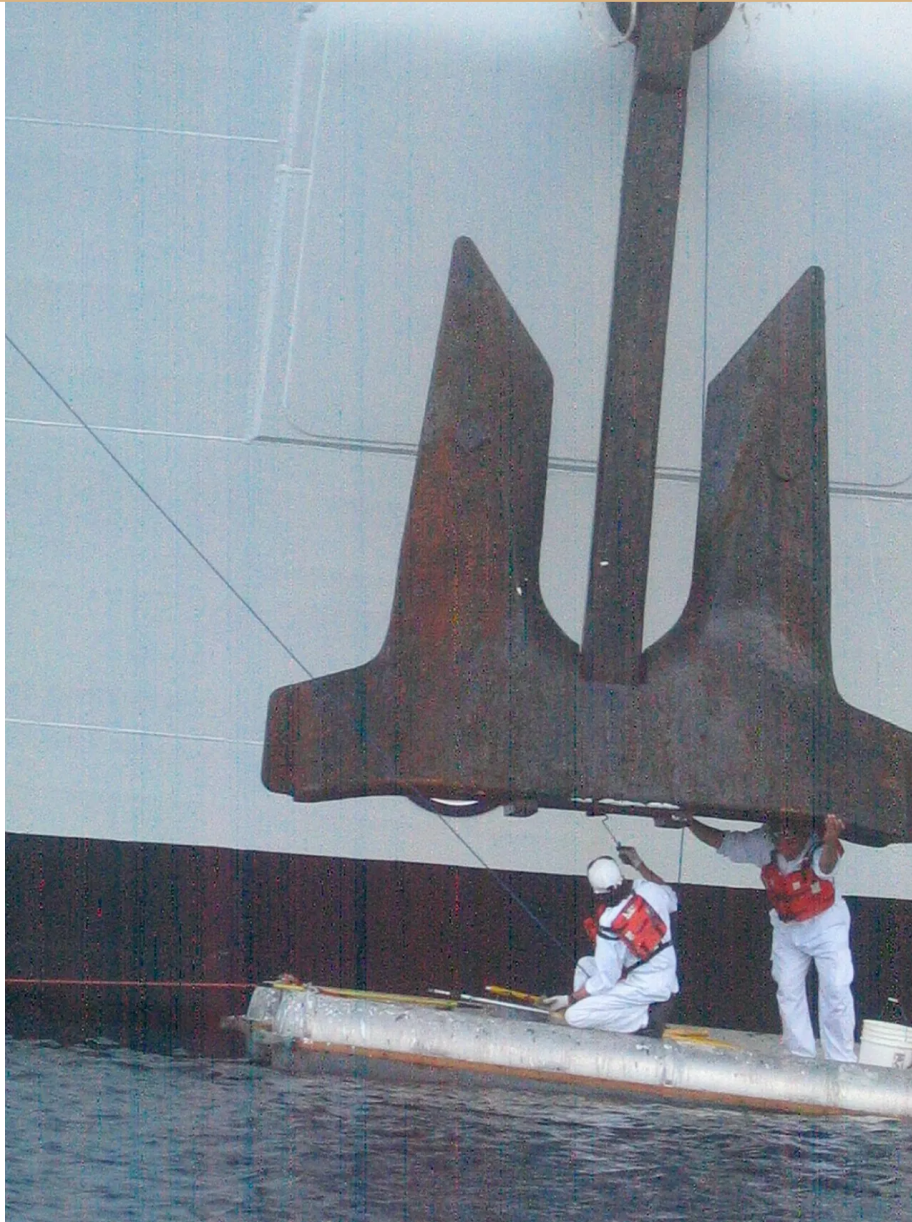
Afternoon: - **Pool deck** at the family pool or one of the quieter aft pools. SPF 30 minimum — Caribbean April sun is intense even with the trade-wind cooling. Reapply. - **Trivia, port talks, live music** — MSC schedules port-arrival briefings on Day 2 for the next day's port (Roatán). Worth attending if it's your first time at any of the upcoming ports. - **Specialty dining reservations.** If you didn't book Eataly online pre-cruise, walk up to the host stand mid-afternoon to see what's available. The 7:30 – 8:30 PM slots fill first.

Evening — likely Gala Evening or group dinner.

MSC typically schedules one of the week's two Gala Evenings for the first sea day of a 7-night sailing — verify in your daily program. Smart-casual is the standard; if it's Gala, dress slightly nicer (suit jacket, cocktail dress) but not formal. The buffet stays open for guests who'd rather skip Gala.

If Denise's group is gathering for dinner, the location and time will be in her Facebook communications. The MDRs (especially Esagono and Hexagon on Deck 6) are the easier rooms to seat a group together; specialty venues like Eataly require pre-booking with a fixed party size.

Day 3 — Monday, April 26 — Roatán, Honduras



Roatán waterfront

Arrival: Approximately 8:00 AM. **Depart:** 5:00 PM. World America docks at the **Port of Roatán at Coxen Hole** — the pier at the island’s working capital on the central-north coast, and the one used by MSC, Royal Caribbean, NCL, and Virgin. (Roatán’s *other* cruise pier, **Mahogany Bay** — recently rebranded *Isla Tropicale* — is Carnival Corporation’s exclusive facility for Carnival and Princess ships; World America does **not** call there. Don’t let a “Mahogany Bay” reference in a generic Roatán guide confuse you.) Confirm your berth in the MSC for Me app.

Roatán — reef, beaches, and the excursion-pricing catch. Roatán is the largest of Honduras's Bay Islands, sitting on the Mesoamerican Reef — the world's second-largest barrier reef. Clear water, friendly locals, snorkeling that converts non-snorkelers into snorkelers, and a developing-country pricing structure where ship-sponsored excursions cost noticeably more than independently arranged alternatives. The island is the cruiser-friendly face of Honduras; if you've heard anything about Honduras as a country, none of it applies to a day on Roatán.

Free / low-cost, at the Port of Roatán (Coxen Hole):

- The port's shopping-and-dining complex at the pier — shops, restaurants, tour desks, a duty-free area, and taxi/tour touts (haggle, and agree fares before you get in).
- Coxen Hole town is right at the pier — a real, workaday Honduran capital rather than a manicured pier village. Walkable and modest; most cruisers head straight for a beach rather than lingering in town.

Paid (decide ahead):

- **West Bay Beach** — Roatán's signature beach. About 30–40 minutes by taxi from the Port of Roatán at Coxen Hole (~\$6–10/person each way for a shared van; agree the fare first). White sand, calmer water than West End, multiple restaurants, beach chairs for ~\$10–15/day. The day most cruisers come for.
- **Snorkel tour to the Mesoamerican Reef.** Independent operators run tours from West End for ~\$35–55/person; ship excursions run \$80–150/person for similar experiences. Choose ship excursion if you want the guaranteed return-to-ship safety net; choose independent if you're a confident traveler with a watch.
- **Roatán Institute for Marine Sciences (RIMS) dolphin program** — at Anthony's Key Resort; \$90–180/person for swim-with-dolphins, encounter, or trainer-for-a-day programs. Family-friendly; the encounters are well-regulated.
- **Gumbalimba Park** — botanical garden + monkey/iguana encounter + zipline (\$40–80/person depending on what you bundle). Lower-cost full-day option.

For first-timers in Roatán: West Bay Beach via taxi is the highest-value low-stress day. Snorkeling at West Bay's offshore reef (just swim out from the beach, the reef is 30 yards offshore) is among the best beach snorkeling in the Caribbean and costs nothing if you bring your own mask/snorkel.

Pack for Roatán: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen (locally enforced — Roatán's reef is protected), towel (the ship's pool towels are fine), water shoes if you're snorkeling rocky shores, \$40–60 USD cash in small bills (US Dollar is widely accepted; lempiras not necessary), sun hat, polarized sunglasses.

Worth a look on the way in: the **Roatán port page**, its **photo gallery**, and the **Roatán logbook** — what other travelers noticed at West Bay, the reef snorkel routes, the taxi rhythms. Build your day in the **Port Day Planner** before you go ashore.

Monday evening: likely casual dining. Check Denise's group plan for whether a group dinner is on tonight.

Day 4 — Tuesday, April 27 — Costa Maya, Mexico



Costa Maya pier complex — purpose-built Mexican cruise port with the Yucatán coast beyond

Arrival: Approximately 9:00 AM. **Depart:** 6:00 PM.

Costa Maya — the purpose-built port, for better and worse. A Mexican government-built cruise port on the Yucatán's Caribbean coast — purpose-designed for cruise ships. The pier complex itself is large, manicured, and contains shops, restaurants, a small zoo, swimming pools, and excursion meeting points. It's the easiest of the Mexican ports — everything is walkable from the ship, beach access is nearby, and the developed area is genuinely pleasant. It's also the *least* “authentic Mexico” of the Yucatán cruise ports — feels more like a resort than a port town. That's not a value judgment; it's information.

Easy-day option (no taxi needed):

- Stay in the Costa Maya port complex. **Tropicante** beach area is a 10-minute walk from the gangway — chairs \$10–15, drinks for purchase, buffet for purchase. The pool complex inside the port (the central plaza area) is free with your cruise card.

Half-day option:

- **Mahahual village** (~10 min by shared shuttle, ~\$4/person each way) — a small fishing town turned cruiser stop. The *malecón* (waterfront walk) has restaurants, beach access, and shops less crowded than the port complex.

Full-day option:

- **Chacchoben Mayan ruins** (~45 min by tour bus). Independent tour operators outside the pier offer this for ~\$50/person; ship excursions run ~\$80–100. Worth it if you have any interest in Mayan history — the ruins are smaller and less restored than Tulum but less crowded and closer to the port. A real archaeological site, not a reconstruction.
- **Bacalar lagoon “Lake of Seven Colors”** — about 1.5 hours each way; full-day excursion only via ship or pre-booked tour (\$120–180/person). Worth the bus ride if you have a swimsuit-day appetite — the layered freshwater colors and the floating wood-plank platforms are unique on this itinerary.

For solo travelers: Costa Maya is the easiest of the Mexican ports for an unstructured day. The pool complex inside the gated area is wheelchair-accessible, has shaded loungers, and is only 5 minutes from re-boarding. If you want a low-energy day to recover from Roatán snorkeling, this is the one.

Pack for Costa Maya: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen, light cover-up, \$40–60 USD cash, small backpack for shopping. You can return to the ship for lunch easily.

Worth a look: the **Costa Maya port page**, its **gallery**, and the **Costa Maya logbook**.

Day 5 — Wednesday, April 28 — Cozumel, Mexico



Cozumel waterfront

Arrival: Approximately 9:00 AM. **Depart:** 7:00 PM (or later — Cozumel is often a late-departure port).

World America typically docks at one of three Cozumel piers — **Punta Langosta** (downtown), **International Pier**, or **Puerta Maya**. Check the MSC for Me app. Cozumel is the most heavily visited Caribbean port; expect 3–5 ships in port the same day during peak season.

Cozumel — the Western Caribbean’s dive capital. This is the underwater destination of the Western Caribbean. The reef system off Cozumel — protected within Cozumel Reefs National Park since 1996 — delivers visibility consistently among the best in the Caribbean. If anyone in your group has ever wanted to try snorkeling, this is the day to do it. Above water, Cozumel feels touristed in a familiar way — it’s been a cruise stop for 50 years and the routine is well-established.

Easy-day option (no excursion needed):

- Stay near your pier. **Punta Langosta** puts you directly in downtown San Miguel — walk around, find a real Mexican lunch (\$15–25/person at a non-tourist restaurant), shop at **Mercado Municipal** (the local market, NOT the tourist shops near the pier — locals shop there too). International and Puerta Maya are 5–10 minutes from downtown by taxi (~\$10).

Half-day options:

- **Chankanaab Beach Adventure Park** (~\$50/person entry, ~15 min by taxi). Calm water, snorkel rentals, dolphin program (paid extra), lounge and umbrella. Family-friendly; the calmest reef snorkeling.
- **Paradise Beach** (~\$3 entry, free chairs with food/drink minimum, ~15 min by taxi). Lower-key alternative to Chankanaab with a real “Mexican beach club” feel.

Full-day options:

- **Palancar Reef snorkel tour** — *the iconic Cozumel experience*. Multiple operators on the pier offer this for \$40–60/person (ship excursion: \$80–110). Two-hour tour, calm water, abundant fish life. If you’ve never snorkeled in clear water, this is the trip that converts you. Bring an underwater camera.
- **Tulum ruins** (3-hour ferry + bus, \$90–150 ship excursion or ~\$80 independent). Long day. April afternoons can hit 90°F + humidity; heat-sensitive travelers should consider Chichén Itzá-Tulum tour timing.

A note on shopping: Cozumel's pier shops sell you the same Mexican blanket, the same silver jewelry, and the same vanilla extract you can buy at any Caribbean cruise port. The interesting shopping is at **Mercado Municipal** in San Miguel (15-min walk from Punta Langosta) — vanilla, ceramics, leather, and food vendors at local-shopper prices.

For wheelchair users and limited mobility: Cozumel is genuinely accessible at the piers. Punta Langosta connects directly to a paved boardwalk into San Miguel. Beach clubs have beach wheelchairs available; ask in advance. Snorkel *boats* are typically NOT accessible — book a beach-snorkel tour instead of a boat tour.

Pack for Cozumel: swimsuit, reef-safe sunscreen, water shoes, sun hat, \$60–80 USD cash for tour and lunch, small underwater camera if you have one.

Worth a look: the **Cozumel port page**, its **gallery**, and the **Cozumel logbook**.

Wednesday evening: Late departure means the ship doesn't leave until after dinner. If you didn't make it onboard for lunch, no rush — the all-aboard call is ~6:30 PM.

Day 6 — Thursday, April 29 — Cruising at sea

The week's second sea day. By now the group has formed; the rhythm is familiar; the cabin feels lived-in. This is the recovery day before Ocean Cay.

Morning ideas:

- **The Aurea Spa** if you didn't book it on Day 2 — thermal-suite day passes still appear in the morning slots.
- **Breakfast at La Brasserie** (Deck 19) — the second sea day is when the buffet rush has settled and you can sit by the window with coffee for an hour.
- **The Galleria atrium** at sunrise — the LED ceiling cycles a different scene by hour of day.

Mid-morning to early afternoon:

- **A laundry round.** Most MSC cabins have no in-cabin washer/dryer; the self-service laundrettes (verify location with your steward) are quietest on the second sea day. Pack quarters or use your cruise card.
- **The pool deck.** With Ocean Cay coming Friday, the second sea day is the right day to lounge — Friday's beach day will mean more direct sun and less shade than the ship's pool umbrellas.
- **Specialty lunch.** Eataly's lunch service is quieter than dinner; if you wanted to try the pasta but couldn't get an evening reservation, lunch usually has walk-up availability.

Afternoon:

- **Port talk for Ocean Cay** — MSC schedules a Day-6 briefing on Ocean Cay logistics. Worth attending: it covers the lighthouse-show schedule (does this sailing have an overnight or late-departure call? answer determines whether the lighthouse show runs in full), the tender vs. dock arrangement (you'll dock alongside, no tender), and the beach map.
- **Group activity** if Denise has scheduled a second hosted moment — check her Facebook page or onboard communications.

Evening — possible Gala Evening #2:

MSC schedules a second Gala Evening typically on the second sea day of a 7-night sailing. Smart-casual works for any other night; Gala invites a slightly dressier outfit. The buffet stays open as the casual alternative.

Tonight is the right night for a specialty dinner you skipped earlier in the week — the second sea day has the calmest lines at Butcher's Cut, Paxos, and the Kaito Japanese venues.

Day 7 — Friday, April 30 — Ocean Cay, Bahamas



The signature view — a “WE ♥ OCEAN CAY” boat-bench on white sand with the red-and-white striped Marine Reserve lighthouse on the spit behind it, beach umbrellas flanking either side

Arrival: Typical pattern is 9:00 AM to evening; some sailings carry an overnight call. **Verify your arrival/departure window in the MSC for Me app** — the answer determines whether you’ll see the lighthouse evening show.

World America **docks alongside** Ocean Cay’s deep-water pier — no tender. Gangway to sand is about 5–10 minutes’ walk.



MSC Seaside (a sister-line ship in the same MSC berth) alongside Ocean Cay's deep-water pier — World America uses the same dock; no tender

Ocean Cay — from aragonite mine to private island. MSC's private island — and only MSC's. Located in the Bimini chain of the Bahamas, ~65 miles east of Miami and ~20 miles south of Bimini. Until 2015 the cay was an industrial aragonite-mining operation (calcium-carbonate sand dredged for cement and glass production). MSC bought it, spent ~\$200 million and four years rebuilding it as a cruise-line private island, and opened it in December 2019. The transformation involved removing all industrial infrastructure, dredging the swim lagoon, planting thousands of palms, and building the striped lighthouse that anchors the island visually.

Ocean Cay is deliberately different from CocoCay, Half Moon Cay, and Castaway Cay. No waterpark, no helium balloon, no zip line, no overwater cabanas. What it has instead: an engineered swim lagoon, the lighthouse (and an evening light-and-music show on overnight or late-departure calls), the Marine Conservation Center, and seven named beaches with distinct personalities. Smaller and quieter than CocoCay. First-timers expecting waterpark-and-fireworks will call it boring; veterans comparing private islands rate it highly for what it deliberately chooses not to be.

Free with your cruise fare:

- **All seven beaches** — South Beach, Lighthouse Bay, Bimini Beach, Pineapple Beach, Seakers Family Cove, Sunset Beach, Ocean House Beach. All sand, all included, all walkable from the pier or via free tram.
- **Loungers and umbrellas** at the main beach areas.
- **Tram service** — runs the spine of the cay, free, accommodates wheelchairs and strollers.
- **Buffet lunch** at the Marketplace Buffet near the pier (and sit-down options at Boho House, Seakers, Smiling Fish — inclusion status varies by venue; verify in the MSC for Me app before counting on a complimentary sit-down).
- **The Beach Shack** at South Beach — chalkboard menu of cheeseburger, hot dog, fries, chicken nuggets, brownie. 11 AM to 4 PM.

- **Lighthouse climb** during posted hours.
- **Marine Conservation Center tours** — scheduled hours, free.

Paid add-ons:

- **Cabana rentals** — multiple tiers, beach-side to premium. Pre-book in the MSC for Me app (typically cheaper pre-cruise than dockside).
- **Reserved beach beds** at certain beaches.
- **Snorkel-gear rental** at the watersports hut.
- **Specialty restaurant covers** at the higher-end sit-down venues.
- **Spa Ocean Cay** treatments.



The engineered swim lagoon viewed through the breakwater — calm, contained turquoise, with South Beach umbrellas visible at the far end

The beaches — quick read on personalities:

- **South Beach** — the center, the busiest, where the Beach Shack and the swim lagoon are. Default destination for first-timers.
- **Seakers Family Cove** — protected family swim area with reef structure creating shallow zones. Best for groups with mixed swimming abilities — no parent-split required.

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- **Bimini Beach and Pineapple Beach** — twin beaches on the west side, calmer water, often less crowded than South Beach. Good for late-morning arrivals.
 - **Lighthouse Bay** — east side, next to the tower. Quieter cove with photogenic views of the lighthouse. Best for evening-show seating if the show runs your night.
 - **Ocean House Beach** (far north) — longest walk from the pier, least crowded. Worth the walk if you want serious quiet.
 - **Sunset Beach** (south end) — still partly under construction; quieter end of the cay.



Ocean Cay's red-and-white striped lighthouse seen across the cruise pier, with the thatched-roof Lighthouse Bar at its base and the swim-zone buoy line in the channel — the first thing you see from the gangway

The lighthouse evening show. A 15-minute lighting-and-music performance synchronized to Bahamian instrumentation. The 98-foot striped tower lights in red-and-white bands, then blue, then climbing gold; projections climb the perforated metal cladding; Spanish guitar carries through the speakers. **The show is free, no ticket required, and the show runs only on overnight or late-departure calls.** Check your itinerary: if you're a daytime-only call, the tower is lit but the full show doesn't run. If your sailing has the show, the Lighthouse Bay beach seating area is where to watch from; the World Promenade deck of the ship is a workable backup. *(Our image archive is daytime-only — the show is best experienced in person.)*

The Marine Conservation Center. Real, not branding. The MSC Foundation operates it; coral nursery work, turtle-nesting protection on the cay's beaches. Visitors tour during scheduled hours, free. ~6-minute walk from the pier. Ocean Cay carries a Mission Blue Hope Spot designation.

Pack for Ocean Cay:

- **MSC cruise card** — required for entry and all purchases. **Cash is not needed on the cay.**
- **Reef-safe sunscreen** — reapply often; Bahamian late-April sun is intense and the cay has limited natural shade away from the umbrellas.
- **Waterproof phone case** for swim-lagoon photos.
- **Hat and sunglasses.**
- **Flip-flops AND water shoes** — the limestone shoreline gets rocky away from the swim cove.
- **A swim shirt** if you burn easily — the cay has limited natural shade.

Pitfalls and things to know:

- **Limited natural shade.** Bring a swim shirt or rent an umbrella early.
- **Construction visible.** The cay's south spit is still under active expansion — expect crane and barge sightings.

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- **Beach Shack vs. sit-down venues.** Beach Shack is hot-dogs-and-nuggets at lunch. The sit-down buffet and labeled restaurants have real food. Don't let the chalkboard menu shape your expectation of what the cay's food is.
 - **Inclusion status not always clearly posted.** Verify in the MSC for Me app or ask a venue host before counting on complimentary status at a sit-down.
 - **No passport stamp.** Ocean Cay is a private island; you don't formally enter the Bahamas.

Worth a look: the **Ocean Cay port page** — extensive coverage of the cay's history, the beach personalities, the lighthouse show, the accessibility design, and persona-style logbook entries from prior visitors.

Day 8 — Saturday, May 1 — PortMiami (debarkation)

The realistic timeline:

- **6:00 – 8:00 AM:** Breakfast available at the buffet (Il Mercato or La Brasserie). Eat now if your bag is in the hall already.
- **7:00 AM:** Customs clearance complete. Self-disembarkation begins for cruisers carrying their own bags.
- **7:30 – 10:00 AM:** Walk-off in waves. **All passengers off the ship by 10:00 AM** per MSC standard.

The bag situation. The night before, MSC asks you to place your checked luggage outside your cabin door by ~11 PM with the color-coded tag indicating your debark group. Bags are taken to the terminal overnight and you collect them in baggage claim before customs.

Carry-on with you on debark morning: a change of clothes for the journey home, all medications, passport, phone charger, valuables, anything you can't bear to lose if a bag is misrouted.

Getting from PortMiami to MIA:

- **Uber/Lyft:** \$30–45, 20–30 minutes. Surge-priced Saturday morning is real; pre-book if possible.

-
- **Cruise Connections shared shuttle** (\$25–35/person, advance booking only) — formal port-to-airport option. Slower than Uber.
 - **Public transit (Metromover + Metrorail):** Technically possible but the bag transfers between modes are rough. Not recommended for a cruise return.

MIA without an Uber. The simple answer: Uber/Lyft on a Saturday afternoon, \$30–45, 25–30 minutes. The math works out.

Airport-arrival timing. For a domestic flight after 4 PM, leave PortMiami by 1:30 PM. For an international flight after 6 PM, leave by 2:30 PM. MIA TSA lines run 30–60 min during the Saturday-afternoon cruise return rush.

Killing 4–6 hours before an evening flight. If you’ve debarked at 8 AM and your flight isn’t until 5 PM, options:

- **Bayfront Park / Bayside Marketplace** — 10-minute walk from PortMiami. Outdoor shopping/dining waterfront. Bag storage available at a few vendors.
- **Pérez Art Museum Miami (PAMM)** — 15-minute walk. \$20 entry. Strong contemporary collection; air-conditioned.
- **Brickell** — short Uber. Cuban coffee at Versailles outpost, lunch at one of the new restaurants, take an Uber to MIA when you’re ready.
- **Pre-paid airport lounge access** — MIA has Priority Pass, American Express Centurion, and Delta Sky Club options if you have the credit cards or memberships. Worth it for a 4-hour layover with a meal and a shower.

Bag storage. If you need to ditch bags between debark and flight: PortMiami doesn’t run an official luggage-storage program, but vendors at Bayside Marketplace sometimes hold bags for \$5–10/bag/day. Confirm before counting on it.

Section 3 — Pre-Cruise Countdown

8+ months before — booking and big decisions

- **Confirm the booking with Tina.** Cabin category, final price, what's included (drinks package tier, Wi-Fi tier, gratuities prepaid or not, specialty dining package).
- **Buy travel insurance** if you want it. **Recommended for any Caribbean cruise** because of hurricane risk in late season. April is pre-hurricane-season (June 1 is the official start), so weather risk for this specific sailing is low — but trip-cancellation coverage for non-weather reasons (illness, family emergency, job change) is still worth considering. Specialist providers (Allianz, Travelex, Travel Guard) are usually better than your home/auto insurer's add-on.
- **Plan flights to Miami.** MIA is the obvious airport; FLL (Fort Lauderdale, ~30 min north) is also workable and sometimes cheaper. Arrive at minimum the day before sailing (Friday April 23, 2027). Same-day flights are not advised — afternoon Florida thunderstorms can ground flights with no notice.
- **Choose Friday-night hotel.** Brickell, Downtown Miami, or Miami Beach put you within easy reach of PortMiami Saturday morning.

4 months before — soft logistics

- **MSC for Me account.** Set up your online check-in; complete the health questionnaire close to sailing (some MSC questions are time-limited and expire if filled too early).
- **Specialty dining reservations.** MSC opens specialty dining reservations ~3–4 months pre-cruise in MSC for Me. **Eataly fills first.** If you only want one specialty meal, book Eataly for the second sea day (Day 6) when you've gotten the ship rhythm down.
- **Excursion bookings.** Ship-sold excursions are bookable in MSC for Me; independent operators in Roatán and Cozumel typically have email-only booking 60–90 days out.

2 months before — final commitments

- **Pre-pay gratuities** if you're going to (it's a small discount vs. onboard rates) — confirm with Tina whether group rate already includes pre-paid gratuities.
- **Drink package upgrades.** If you want to upgrade from Easy to Easy+ or Premium Plus, pre-cruise rates are 15–20% cheaper than onboard.
- **Confirm pre-cruise hotel.**
- **Begin packing list.** Reference **Section 4** below.

1 month before — final prep window

- **Photocopy your passport** — keep a copy in your cabin nightstand separate from the passport itself.
- **Print the emergency handoff card** and share it with one trusted person ashore.
- **Buy travel insurance** if you haven't.
- **Confirm with Denise** what the group's Day 1 sailaway gathering plan is.

14 days before — soft logistics

- **MSC online check-in closes** typically at 7 days pre-cruise — complete it earlier if you can.
- **Print boarding documents** (or save offline in MSC for Me on your phone).
- **Begin physical packing.**

Day before — Miami arrival

- **Fly into MIA or FLL Friday.**
 - **Check into Friday-night hotel.**
 - **Confirm porter/cab/Uber timing for Saturday morning.**
-

Section 4 — Packing List (calibrated for late-April Caribbean)

This list is tuned for: **late-April Western Caribbean** — 80–88°F daytime, 75–80°F evenings, occasional brief afternoon showers, water temperature 78–82°F. **Four port days** mostly walking and beach. **Two sea days. One private-island beach day** (Ocean Cay). **MSC's smart-casual evening dress culture** (no strict formal nights; one or two Gala Evenings invite a slightly dressier outfit but jacket not required).

Documents and money

- **Passport** (strongly preferred for Caribbean itineraries — Roatán and Mexico are foreign ports; passport is the cleanest documentation)
- Photocopy of passport (separate location from passport itself)
- Travel insurance policy and emergency phone number (printed)
- Credit card + debit card (separate locations, in case one is lost)
- **\$200–300 USD cash** in small bills (\$1s, \$5s, \$10s) for tips, taxis, and small purchases ashore — broken across your wallet, day-pack, and cabin safe
- MSC cruise documents (printed boarding pass + saved offline in MSC for Me app)
- Group itinerary from Denise (if she's shared one)

Carry-on (must arrive on the ship with you)

- All medications in original prescription bottles
- Phone + charger + power bank
- Refillable water bottle (you'll use this every day)
- Light layer (Miami evenings can be 75°F outdoors but ship interior runs 70°F)
- Swimsuit (pools open before checked bags arrive)

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- A change of clothes (in case checked bag is delayed)
 - Sunglasses, sun hat, reef-safe sunscreen (Roatán and Cozumel require reef-safe)
 - Reading material (your sea-day reading)

Daytime — port and ship

- **5–6 swimsuits** (you'll be in water 5 of 7 days; rotating swimsuits is a quality-of-life upgrade)
- **2 swim cover-ups** (for moving between cabin and pool/beach)
- **3–4 quick-dry t-shirts or tank tops** (port wear and pool-deck wear)
- **2 pairs lightweight shorts**
- **1–2 pairs lightweight pants** (Mayan ruins / mosquito-protective in Roatán late afternoon)
- **1 lightweight long-sleeve shirt** (sun protection at Ocean Cay if you burn easily; mosquito protection if you do excursions inland)
- **1 light cardigan or wrap** (for ship AC indoors; evenings on deck)

Evening — ship dining

- **4–5 smart-casual outfits** — sundresses, lightweight pants + nicer top, lightweight dress slacks + button-down. MSC's evening dress code is European-casual: nicer than American casual, less formal than American legacy lines.
- **1 Gala Evening outfit** (cocktail dress, dressy jumpsuit, dress slacks + jacket, dressy separates) — wearable twice across the week's two Gala Evenings if needed
- **Comfortable dress shoes** that handle long carpeted corridors (heels should be low; the ship's gentle motion + tile-to-carpet transitions make stilettos a bad idea)

Footwear

- **Comfortable walking shoes** (sneakers or sandals) — for ship corridors and dry port days
- **Water shoes** (Cozumel snorkeling, rocky shorelines, Ocean Cay limestone) — strongly recommended
- **Flip-flops** (pool deck and cabin)
- **Dress shoes** — one pair only for the week's evenings

Toiletries

- All prescription medications (carried in original bottles, in your carry-on)
- Over-the-counter standbys: Tylenol, Advil, Imodium, Benadryl, Dramamine (or Bonine — see **Section 7**)
- Reef-safe sunscreen (SPF 30+ minimum, SPF 50 if you burn easily; **reef-safe is enforced in Roatán and Cozumel**)
- After-sun aloe gel
- Insect repellent (DEET 25%+ or picaridin) for inland excursions
- Toothbrush, toothpaste, deodorant, basic toiletries
- Hair care for humidity (anti-frizz product or hair tie/clip)
- Lip balm with SPF

Accessories and essentials

- Polarized sunglasses (reduces water glare and protects eyes — essential, not optional)
- Sun hat with brim
- Small daypack for port days
- Waterproof phone case (snorkeling + Ocean Cay swim lagoon)
- Beach towel? — MSC provides pool/beach towels at the pool deck and at Ocean Cay; you don't need to pack one
- Binoculars if you want them (whale and bird spotting; some operators provide for snorkel tours)

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- **Power adapter** — MSC World America has US and EU outlets; basic US plugs work fine, but a USB-multiplier strip is useful for charging multiple devices
 - **E-reader or one book** (sea-day reading)

Skip — what NOT to bring

- **Iron or steamer** — prohibited in cabins; ships provide ironing facilities
 - **Candles** — prohibited (fire hazard)
 - **Multipack hangers** — cabins have adequate hangers
 - **Heavy jewelry** — the cabin safe handles essentials; leave high-value pieces home
 - **Cash-heavy wallet** — Ocean Cay is cashless; ship is cashless; Mexican ports take USD; only Roatán benefits from small-bill USD
 - **Multiple formal outfits** — MSC's "Gala" is two evenings max and not strict formal
 - **Beach umbrella or pop-up shade** — Ocean Cay rents umbrellas; the ship pool deck has shade; you don't need to pack one
-
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Section 5 — Budget Breakdown

The numbers below are calibrated for this specific sailing. For a budget tuned to your own cabin choice, drinking habits, excursion appetite, and tipping pattern, the **cruise-budget-calculator** builds a personalized total — usually within 5% of what you'll actually spend if you input honestly.

What's included in your fare

The group rate covers:

- Your cabin (Solo Studio, Ocean View, Interior, or Balcony per your booking)

- All meals in the MDRs, buffet (Il Mercato, La Brasserie), Luna Park Pizza & Burger, La Boca Grill, Promenade Bites
- Soft drinks, juice, coffee, tea at most venues (specifics depend on your fare type — Bella, Fantastica, or Aurea)
- Onboard entertainment in the World Theatre, The Loft, Luna Park Arena
- Pools, fitness center, the Venom Drop dry slide
- Tendering (not needed on this itinerary — World America docks alongside at all ports)
- Cabin steward and dining-room service

What's NOT included

The realistic add-on costs:

Category	Typical cost (per person, week)
Drinks package (if not in your fare)	\$400–700 — Easy: ~\$50/day · Premium Plus: ~\$80/day
Wi-Fi package	\$80–180 — varies by tier
Service charge / gratuities	~\$119 — \$17/day standard (\$23/day Yacht Club); rate effective May 11, 2026; verify if pre-paid in your group rate
Specialty dining	\$0–250 — Eataly ~\$45 · Butcher's Cut ~\$55 · Paxos ~\$40 (per meal)
Shore excursions — Roatán	\$0–150 — taxi to West Bay ~\$15; snorkel tour ~\$40 indep / ~\$100 ship
Shore excursions — Costa Maya	\$0–100 — port complex free; Chacchoben ~\$50 indep / ~\$80 ship
Shore excursions — Cozumel	\$0–110 — independent snorkel ~\$50; ship Palancar ~\$95; Tulum ~\$120
Ocean Cay add-ons	\$0–250 — cabanas \$150–300; snorkel rental ~\$25
Spa treatments	\$0–500 — massages \$130–200 · thermal-suite day pass \$40

Category	Typical cost (per person, week)
Photos	\$0–250 — Photo Package ~\$200 (worth it on Gala Evening)

A realistic mid-range solo budget (per person, on top of cruise fare)

Item	Cost
Gratuities (\$17/day × 7)	\$119
Wi-Fi (Browse package)	\$90
Drinks package upgrade (Easy → Easy+)	\$200
Specialty dining (Eataly + Paxos)	\$85
Roatán: taxi + lunch	\$35
Costa Maya: lunch + ruins tour	\$70
Cozumel: snorkel tour + lunch	\$80
Ocean Cay: drinks + extras	\$40
Airport transfers MIA  port	\$80
Pre-cruise hotel (Friday night Brickell mid-range)	\$180
Tips above and beyond	\$30
Total above fare	~\$1,010

Frugal version (no specialty dining, no upgraded drink package, public transit and shared shuttles where possible): **~\$420 above fare.**

Splurge version (Yacht Club, premium drinks, multiple specialty meals, helicopter tour from Roatán): **\$2,500–4,000 above fare.**

Section 6 — Emergency Contacts

Every Voyage Pack ships with this section. If you're the cruiser preparing for the trip, fill in the handoff card and share it with one trusted person ashore.

The family handoff card

Copy this, fill in your specifics, and share:

FAMILY HANDOFF – IN THE WAKE VOYAGE PACK

CRUISER: _____
 CABIN: _____
 SHIP: MSC World America
 LINE: MSC Cruises
 SAILING: April 24 – May 1, 2027
 FROM: MSC Miami Cruise Terminal, PortMiami,
 Miami, FL, USA
 ITINERARY: Miami → Roatán (Honduras) →
 Costa Maya (Mexico) → Cozumel (Mexico)
 → Ocean Cay (Bahamas) → Miami
 GROUP HOST: Denise Sheets Ferguson
 (Facebook: DeniseSheetsFerguson)
 BOOKING AGENT: Tina Maulsby, Maulsby Travel Co.
 tina@maulsbytravel.com · 910-528-5077

EMERGENCY (24/7) – US State Dept, Overseas
 Citizens Services (can locate the ship and
 reach MSC through official channels, no cost):
 +1 (888) 407-4747 (US/Canada)
 +1 (202) 501-4444 (from abroad)

MSC GUEST RELATIONS (to reach a guest aboard –
 business hours ET; have ship name, sail date,
 guest name & booking #):
 +1 (877) 665-4655

SHIP-TO-SHORE: In emergency, MSC relays to ship

NEAREST EMBASSY/CONSULATE BY PORT:

Miami, FL – US domestic; call 911
 Roatán, HN – US Consulate Tegucigalpa:
 +504 2236-9320
 (after-hours emergency)
 Costa Maya, MX – US Consulate Mérida:
 +1 (844) 528-6611 (US) / 999 689-0660
 Cozumel, MX – US Consulate Mérida (as above);
 also Cancún Consular Agency:
 +1 (844) 528-6611 (US)
 Ocean Cay, BS – MSC private island; ship's
 medical & security on-island

CRUISER MEDICAL:

Allergies: _____
 Medications: _____
 Conditions: _____

Insurance: _____ policy: _____

MOST RECENT KNOWN POSITION:

Track at: </tools/ship-tracker.html>
or marinetraffic.com (search "MSC World America")

What an at-home contact actually does

If they don't hear from you for 36+ hours and they're worried:

1. **Don't panic.** Cruise Wi-Fi is unreliable and silence usually means signal, not emergency.
2. **For a true emergency, call the State Department's Overseas Citizens Services line** (above) — it runs 24/7 and can locate the ship and reach MSC through official channels at no cost. To pass a non-urgent message to you aboard, **MSC Guest Relations** (877-665-4655, business hours ET) can relay to the ship.
3. **Reach out to Denise via Facebook Messenger** — she's your in-person on the ship and likely has eyes on the group sooner than family ashore can.
4. **Reach Tina at Maulsby Travel** if there's a booking question or if MSC's Guest Services line isn't getting through.
5. **If MSC confirms an incident or you're not aboard:** US Consulate Tegucigalpa for Honduras; US Consulate Mérida for Mexican ports; for Bahamas the ship's resources cover Ocean Cay.
6. **Track the ship's position** using the link above for context.

What you should pack for emergencies

- Printed list of medications, allergies, and emergency contacts (in your cabin nightstand)
- Photocopy of passport (separate from the passport itself)
- Travel insurance policy number (printed)
- The handoff card above, in your phone's notes app and shared with one trusted person

Section 7 — Seasickness

Late-April Western Caribbean is among the calmer Caribbean weeks of the year. The Gulf of Mexico and Yucatán Channel can chop briefly but rarely produce serious motion. The biggest motion exposure is the Day-2 sea day (Gulf of Mexico southwest transit) and the Day-6 sea day (returning north). Both are usually mild.

If you're prone to motion sickness:

- **Bonine (meclizine)** — once-daily, less drowsy than Dramamine. Start the morning of Day 2 sea day if forecast suggests motion; otherwise take only as needed.
- **Sea-bands (acupressure wristbands)** — placebo or not, many find them effective.
- **Ginger** (capsules, tea, candies) — mild but real anti-nausea effect.
- **Scopolamine patches** (prescription, behind-the-ear) — strongest option, prescribed pre-cruise; 3-day duration.
- **Stay mid-ship and low** in your cabin choice. Higher decks and bow/stern cabins feel more motion. Mid-ship Deck 8–12 has the least felt motion.

If you get sick onboard: the ship's medical center stocks IV anti-nausea medication. Bring travel insurance — onboard medical bills are real and not covered by US health insurance.

Section 8 — Practical Logistics

Cell service and roaming

- **At sea** — ship Wi-Fi only; turn airplane mode ON. Cellular at sea via the ship's onboard cell tower roams at \$5–10/minute and 50¢/text; do NOT use without confirming.
- **Roatán** — Honduran carriers Tigo, Claro. Your US carrier roams at international rates; check your plan. A local SIM is overkill for a day.
- **Costa Maya / Cozumel** — Mexican carriers Telcel, AT&T Mexico. US T-Mobile customers get included roaming in Mexico; Verizon and AT&T-US have day-pass rates ~\$10/day. Confirm with your carrier pre-cruise.
- **Ocean Cay** — no terrestrial cellular. Ship Wi-Fi only if you bought the package; otherwise you're offline for the day. This is fine.

Currency

- **Aboard:** US Dollar.
- **Roatán:** US Dollar widely accepted; Honduran lempira not necessary. Small bills (\$1, \$5, \$10) are best.
- **Costa Maya / Cozumel:** US Dollar widely accepted at tourist-facing businesses; Mexican peso is the local currency and gets better prices off the tourist track. Credit cards accepted at sit-down restaurants. ATMs are at the pier (~\$3 fee per withdrawal).
- **Ocean Cay:** MSC cruise card only; no cash needed.

Tipping ashore

- **Roatán:** Taxi drivers, snorkel guides, restaurant servers — 10–15% on bills, \$1–2/person on guided tours.
- **Costa Maya / Cozumel:** Mexican tipping practice is 10–15% on restaurant bills, 10–20 pesos for taxi drivers, \$5–10/person for half-day tours.

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- **Ocean Cay:** Tips for bartenders and servers are optional (gratuities are bundled into your fare); \$1–2 per drink to a bartender who took good care of you is appreciated.

Onboard tipping (gratuities)

MSC's daily Hotel Service Charge runs **\$17/person/day** for standard cabins and **\$23/person/day** for Yacht Club suites — the rate that took effect May 11, 2026 — charged to your onboard account. Verify with Tina whether your group rate has the service charge pre-paid; if not, it'll appear on your final bill. For the all-in tipping picture across auto-grats plus typical cash tips for bartenders/cabin steward/concierge, the **cruise-tipping-calculator** gives a calibrated read. For the broader context of why cruise gratuities work the way they do across the major lines in 2026, **Cruise Tipping 2026** is the longer read.

Section 9 — The Group Cruise Rhythm

Denise sets the rhythm. The pattern most hosted solo group cruises follow:

- **Day 1 (Saturday) sailaway:** Denise typically hosts a gathering at a specific bar or lounge for sailaway. Look for her communications on Facebook before sailing. The World Promenade (Deck 8 aft) is the natural gathering spot for sailaway given the wake view.
- **Day 1 group dinner:** Often the casual first-night meal — verify the venue and time with Denise. The MDRs (Deck 5 or 6) seat groups easily; specialty venues require pre-booking with fixed party size.
- **Daily meeting point:** Some hosts pick one fixed location and time (e.g., 5:00 PM at a specific bar) so anyone who wants to find the group can. Look for Denise's pick.
- **Group activities:** The Loft (comedy/karaoke) is a natural group venue; trivia rounds, port talks, and live-music spots in the Galleria all attract group-style gatherings.

-
- **Specialty dinners:** Hosted groups often book one or two specialty dinners as planned group meals (Eataly is the obvious one on World America). If a meal is on the group calendar, RSVP early to Denise.
 - **Port days:** Most hosted groups don't require a port-day group activity; you're on your own schedule unless a specific excursion is being organized.
 - **Last-night dinner:** Friday night (post-Ocean Cay) is the traditional last-night-together gathering. Plan to be aboard by sail-away from Ocean Cay.

How to find Denise on day 1. Watch her Facebook page for the exact location and time of the sailaway gathering. If you don't see communication before boarding, the most likely spot is the World Promenade bar at Deck 8 aft around 4:30 PM (just before the 5:00 PM sailaway).

If you're shy. Group cruises are designed for the shy. You don't have to attend every gathering; you can show up to one dinner, decide you want company, and the group will absorb you naturally. You can also decide you want quiet time and the group won't track you down. The right rhythm is whatever rhythm you set.

Section 10 — Solo Cruising Considerations

Solo cruising on MSC is good, but **different** from solo cruising on NCL or Royal Caribbean. The differences worth knowing:

- **MSC's Solo Studio program** is newer than NCL's. NCL pioneered the no-single-supplement studio cabin concept with their Studio category and dedicated Studio Lounge; MSC's equivalent on newer ships is a growing program but the social architecture isn't quite the same. There's typically not a dedicated Solo Studio lounge with daily hosted hours on MSC the way there is on NCL.
- **European cruise culture.** MSC is an Italian-headquartered line with a European passenger demographic that often outnumbers the American share even on Caribbean sailings. You'll hear Italian, French, Spanish, and

German in the corridors. Most crew are multilingual; most signage is in English first.

- **Different evening rhythm.** MDR dinners run longer and more course-paced than American lines. If you're a fast eater, the buffet is faster; if you want the European-paced multi-course experience, the MDRs deliver it.
- **Family-heavy on Caribbean sailings.** World America's family architecture (The Harbour, Doremiland Kids Clubs, Luna Park Arena) draws families. The pool deck during school-vacation weeks is busy with kids. Late April is post-spring-break for most US schools, so kid density should be lower than peak school-holiday weeks.

For first-time MSC cruisers coming from another line:

- The MSC for Me app is the operational hub — check daily program, book specialty dining, see open ship-restaurant capacity in real time. **Download and log in before sailing.**
- Gratuities are called “Service Charge” not “Daily Service Charge.”
- The drink-package tiers are named differently from your previous line; don't assume “Premium” means the same thing.
- MSC's Yacht Club is a serious step up from regular cabin — if you're considering it, ask Tina for pricing well before sailing.

Solo cruising stories. Tina has written extensively on solo cruising — her **solo cruising hub** collects the practical, the emotional, and the social rhythms across multiple sailings.

Section 11 — First Cruise Notes

If this is your first cruise of any kind, a few foundational notes (the **first-cruise guide** is the deeper read; the **Cruising Duck tradition** is the one piece of cruise culture worth knowing in advance; and the **cruise-tech and photography guide** helps you pack the right cables, mounts, and waterproof cases for World America's signature views):

- **The cabin is small.** Even Balcony cabins are smaller than a budget hotel room. You're not living in the cabin; you're sleeping in it. The ship is your living room.
- **You can't get lost.** Every elevator lobby has a deck map. Every crew member can direct you. The Galleria (Decks 6–8 mid-ship) is the orienting landmark.
- **You don't need to book everything ahead.** The schedule of "must do this" activities you may see online doesn't reflect that most days unfold with significant unplanned time. That's by design.
- **Tipping is built in.** Beyond the auto-gratuity (your daily Service Charge), you don't need to tip every interaction. A few dollars to a great bartender or steward at the end of the week is appreciated but not expected.
- **Don't try to do everything.** A week is enough time to do what matters. Trying to do every show, every specialty restaurant, every port excursion, and every sea-day activity will burn you out by Day 4.

The thing nobody tells first-timers: the best moments of a cruise are usually unplanned. The conversation that happens at the bar on Day 3. The view from your balcony at 6 AM that you weren't expecting. The 30 minutes you spent watching the wake unfold from the World Promenade.

Leave room for that.

Closing

This pack is the calm read on one specific week — yours.

Soli Deo Gloria. All work on this project is offered as a gift to God. The site that produced it is independent — no affiliate links, no commissions, no upsells. If it helped you, that's the whole point.

Safe sailing.

Sources | Ship: **MSC World America**. Ports: **Miami, Roatán, Costa Maya, Cozumel, Ocean Cay**. Articles: **MSC Seaside service review, Royal Caribbean vs MSC**. Hosts: **Denise Sheets Ferguson** (on-ship), **Tina Maulsby** at **Maulsby Travel Co.** (booking). Tools: **drink-calculator, port-day-planner, port-tracker, ship-tracker**. Reference: **solo cruising hub, first-cruise, internet-at-sea, packing-lists, cabin-organization article**. Original research: MSC.com, MSC for Me app documentation, MSC press releases (2025). |